THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK ONE: BEFORE

Chapter 1 — "Happy New Year"

Saturday, December 31, 2022 – Sunday, January 1, 2023

COLD OPEN

EXT. TIMES SQUARE — NEW YORK CITY — NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2022 — 11:56 PM EST

A million people packed between Broadway and Seventh Avenue. Unseasonably warm. Damp from the afternoon rain. Confetti already in the air, too early, because somebody always fires the cannon too early.

On the main stage of ABC's DICK CLARK'S NEW YEAR'S ROCKIN' EVE, under a wall of light, stands TYRESE AVERY (31). Silver jacket, no shirt, a voice that has sold out stadiums on six continents. He hits the last note of his global smash "AFTERGLOW" and holds it so long the crowd starts screaming in the middle of it.

He drops the mic to his side. Grins. Breathless.

TYRESE
New York, I love you. Don't let nobody tell you 2022 won. We outlasted it!

The crowd ROARS. Host RYAN SEACREST (48) jogs on, arm around Tyrese.

RYAN SEACREST
Tyrese Avery, everybody! Three and a half minutes to midnight!

Tyrese leans into Ryan's mic one last time.

TYRESE
And Baldwin Hills, I see y'all. Put the babies to bed!

A camera finds a hand-painted sign in the crowd: "TYRESE MARRY ME (OR JUST WAVE)." He waves. The girl holding it collapses into her friends.

> **Twitter · @tyreseslayss_**
>
> TYRESE SAID "BALDWIN HILLS I SEE Y'ALL" HE'S TALKING TO MARC-ANTHONY AND AMOND I'M SCREAMING
>
> **48.2K Retweets · 211K Likes**

> **Twitter · @RockinEveFan**
>
> Tyrese Avery's "Afterglow" at #RockinEve might be the best live vocal in the show's history. Fight me.
>
> **9,104 Retweets · 63K Likes**

INT. SUNRISE HILL — GREAT ROOM — BEL AIR, LOS ANGELES — NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2022 — 8:57 PM PST

A house that could fit a small airport, decorated like somebody's grandmother still lives in it: family photos on every surface, a basket of mismatched slippers by the door, a crayon drawing of "DADDY AS A DINOSAUR" framed in gold leaf next to an Emmy.

Times Square on a screen the size of a garage door. Thirty people. Pizza boxes stacked next to a caviar tower nobody's touching.

Standing ON the sectional couch, shoes off, holding a sparkling-cider bottle like a championship trophy: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (30). Bel Air sweatpants, a vintage KID MAYOR t-shirt, and the easy, unforced charisma of a man who has been on camera since he was ten and has never once looked like he was trying.

On either side of him, also standing on the couch, also shoeless: his twin daughters. EMMA BULLOCK (10), older by 25 minutes, in a sequin headband she has clearly color-coordinated with her pajamas. And VICTORIA BULLOCK (10), younger, wearing a plastic party crown sideways and a fake mustache she found somewhere.

Between them, holding Marc's free hand: his goddaughter, LYRIC BAKER (8), all cheeks and curls, in a tutu over her pajama pants.

MARC
Ladies and gentlemen, children and Tyler —

TYLER (O.S.)
Wow.

MARC
— this is the EAST COAST midnight. Which, according to the laws of this house, is the REAL midnight for anybody under the age of eleven.

VICTORIA
That's a scam.

MARC
It's a tradition, baby. Traditions are just scams that got old.

Across the room, on a barstool, TYLER CHAPMAN (30), Houston-born, a guitarist's calluses on his fingers and a cowboy hat he wears ironically until someone mentions it, then sincerely.

TYLER
For the record, I'm thirty-one in four days. That makes me the elder of this house.

MARC
By ONE day. You were born on January fourth like a rough draft. God looked at you and said, "Okay. Let's fix it." And the next day — me.

Laughter. TAYIA BOYD (30), Marc's co-star from two childhood sitcoms, eating pizza crust-first like a lunatic, points at Tyler.

TAYIA
He's been saying that since we were twelve. On the Kid Mayor set. Every January.

TYLER
And I'll say it till I die. Respect your elders.

MARC
I respect my elders. That's why I'm putting you in a home.

By the kitchen island, ESTHER BULLOCK (30), barefoot, in a cream silk set, a glass of champagne she's barely touched. Even in a room full of famous people, eyes slide to her and stay. Modern-day Shirley Temple, grown into something more elegant than anyone predicted. She watches Marc with the twins and doesn't even know she's smiling.

Next to her, HARMONY BAKER (30), born on Juneteenth and built like a dancer, because she is one, is already stretching a calf on the counter like it's a barre.

HARMONY
He's going to fall off that couch.

ESTHER
He's been standing on furniture since 2003. He's never fallen once.

HARMONY
That's not a flex. That's a warning.

AMOND BAKER (30), Marc's next-door neighbor since they were four and his brother in every way that matters, slides in behind his wife, kisses her shoulder, and steals her drink.

AMOND
Did y'all hear Tyrese? "Baldwin Hills, I see y'all." He's gonna get us doxxed.

ESTHER
Everybody already knows where Baldwin Hills is, Amond.

AMOND
They don't know which house had the trampoline Marc broke in 1999.

MARC (O.S.)
I HEARD THAT. THAT TRAMPOLINE WAS STRUCTURALLY UNSOUND.

GRACE BULLOCK (28), Marc's baby sister, wearing a "MARC'S LITTLE SISTER (DERISIVE)" t-shirt she had custom-made, is filming everything on her phone.

GRACE
(to her phone)
Day four thousand of my brother standing on a couch he paid three hundred thousand dollars for.

ELXA (O.S.)
Three-eighty.

ELXA BULLOCK (32), the eldest, with a tablet in one hand and a clipboard in the other, on New Year's Eve. She has a run-of-show. For a house party.

ELXA
Three-eighty with the custom fabric. I approved the invoice. Ball drop in ninety seconds, people. Children, hydrate. Tayia, stop eating pizza backwards, it's upsetting the caterers.

TAYIA
The caterers are paid to be upset.

In the corner, on a velvet chair, ARIANNA CUMMINGS (30), the only person in the room still reading, a legal thriller with a dog-eared spine. She closes it as the countdown graphic appears.

ARIANNA
For the record, it's not legally midnight anywhere in California.

MARC
Objection.

ARIANNA
On what grounds?

MARC
On the grounds that Lyric has a bedtime and I have a tradition. Sustained. By me. Ten!

The whole room joins in. On screen, the ball begins to fall.

EVERYONE
NINE! EIGHT! SEVEN!

Lyric squeezes Marc's hand so hard her whole body shakes.

LYRIC
Uncle Marc, are we gonna be in 2023 for real?

MARC
For real for real.

EVERYONE
THREE! TWO! ONE! HAPPY NEW YEAR!

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 12:00:00 AM EST / 9:00 PM PST (DECEMBER 31)

Confetti cannons go off INSIDE THE HOUSE. Elxa looks at the ceiling like she's mentally pricing the cleanup. Marc sweeps all three girls into a hug so big it's mostly arms.

MARC
Happy New Year, my babies. You're one year closer to being taxpayers. I'm so proud.

EMMA
Daddy, that's not a nice thing to say.

MARC
It's the nicest thing in America.

Victoria pulls off her fake mustache and sticks it on Marc's lip.

VICTORIA
Now you look like a senator.

MARC
Take it back.

On the screen, the camera pans the crowd. Tyrese, on stage, is kissed on the cheek by three different strangers.

Instagram · @marcanthonybullock

[Video: Marc, the twins, and Lyric screaming through the countdown on the couch, confetti everywhere, Victoria's fake mustache now on Marc's face] Caption: East Coast midnight. The ONLY midnight that matters when you have a bedtime. Happy New Year from Sunrise Hill. Hydrate. Tip your caterers. Respect your elders except Tyler.

41.6M likes · 892K comments

Instagram comment · @bullpen.headquarters

not victoria putting the mustache on him... "now you look like a senator" HELP

214K likes

Instagram comment · @kidmayorforever

the fact that he's wearing the KID MAYOR shirt. this man knows exactly what he's doing to the millennials

98K likes

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

Marc-Anthony Bullock really celebrated New Year's at 9pm Pacific so his kids could see the ball drop. Richest man on earth and he still does the "fake midnight." I'm not crying you're crying.

31K Retweets · 177K Likes

EXT. SUNRISE HILL — UPPER TERRACE — NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 12:00 AM PST

Three hours later. The REAL West Coast midnight. The kids are asleep: Emma in her own bed with her headband still on, Victoria on the floor of Emma's room because she "fell asleep guarding," Lyric between Amond and Harmony in the guest wing.

Below, the lights of Los Angeles. Somewhere toward downtown, fireworks. A light drizzle starting. The atmospheric river that drowned Northern California today is finally reaching south.

Marc and Esther alone at the railing, under one blanket. Marc still has the fake mustache on.

ESTHER
You know that's still on your face.

MARC
I know. I'm committing to the bit through the first quarter.

The bells of a church in Westwood start ringing. Marc pulls her closer. They kiss. It's soft and practiced and still somehow new. Twenty years of friendship and ten years of everything else.

MARC
Happy New Year, Smilley.

ESTHER
It's Bullock. It's been Bullock for nine years.

MARC
I know. I just like reminding the universe I stole you.

Her phone BUZZES in her robe pocket. She looks. The light hits her face. The smile goes still.

> **DADDY (Cornelius Smilley) — 3:00 AM EST**
>
> Happy New Year, sweetheart. 2023 is the year. Call me tomorrow. We need to discuss the plan. Love, Dad.

Marc doesn't read it. He doesn't need to. He reads her.

MARC
Your dad?

ESTHER
He stayed up until three in the morning Atlanta time to send that. He wants to talk about "the plan."

MARC
The plan where you run for Congress in a state we don't live in.

ESTHER
Marc.

MARC
(gentle)
I'm not mad. I'm never mad at him. I'm just saying. It's midnight. He could've just said Happy New Year and stopped. Most people stop.

ESTHER
He's not most people.

MARC
No. Most people would've come to the wedding.

Beat. She puts the phone away. Leans into him.

ESTHER
Tomorrow.

MARC
Tomorrow. Tonight you're mine, and the twins are asleep, and nobody needs anything from you.

A crash from inside. Then Grace's voice, far away.

GRACE (O.S.)
NOBODY WORRY, IT WAS JUST THE CAVIAR TOWER.

Marc closes his eyes.

MARC
...Almost nobody.

SMASH CUT TO:

ACT ONE — "THIS WEEK"

INT. ABC NEWS — WASHINGTON BUREAU — "THIS WEEK" STUDIO — MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 9:00 AM EST

The show's familiar opening: the Capitol dome, the White House, a fast montage of the year that just ended. Tanks outside Kyiv. Dobbs protesters on the Supreme Court steps. A gas station sign: $5.02. Election-night graphics. A burning crypto logo. A Southwest jet parked at an empty gate.

Then: GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (61), at the anchor desk. Crisp, unhurried, a man who has done this for a very long time.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Good morning, and Happy New Year. Welcome to "This Week." We begin 2023 with a world in mourning, a war that refuses to end, and a Washington that hasn't even convened its new Congress and is already at war with itself. Let's get right to it.

CHYRON: BREAKING: POPE EMERITUS BENEDICT XVI DIES AT 95

Footage: Vatican City. St. Peter's Basilica in gray morning light. Crowds forming.

GEORGE (V.O.)
Pope Emeritus Benedict the Sixteenth died yesterday morning at 9:34 Rome time in the monastery inside Vatican City where he had lived since becoming the first pope in nearly six hundred years to resign. He was ninety-five. His body will lie in state at St. Peter's Basilica beginning tomorrow, and Pope Francis will preside over his funeral on Thursday, an extraordinary moment: a sitting pope burying his predecessor.

INTERCUT — INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — CASCADE HEIGHTS, ATLANTA — SAME TIME

SUPER: 9:02 AM EST

An old-money Black Atlanta parlor: dark wood, crystal, framed photographs of marches and podiums and handshakes with five different Presidents. Over the mantel, in oil, the REV. DR. JOSIAH SMILLEY (1925–2009), in a pulpit robe, one hand raised as if mid-sermon. His painted eyes follow everyone.

In the wingback chair closest to the television, in a church hat even though there's no service until eleven, sits ODESSA SMILLEY (94). She looks seventy, sharp as a scalpel, and has outlived everyone who ever underestimated her.

ODESSA
Benedict. Lord. That man was pope when your daddy passed.

On the leather sofa, a legal pad on his knee, reading glasses low, in a cashmere cardigan that costs more than a car payment: CORNELIUS SMILLEY (64). Looks forty-five. Former Congressman. K Street kingmaker. Even at home on a holiday, he looks like he's about to testify.

CORNELIUS
January of '09. He sent a letter. I still have it.

ODESSA
You still have everything. That's your problem.

LORRAINE SMILLEY (61), Esther's mother, glides in with a silver coffee service and the posture of a woman who once walked the Miss Black America stage and never stopped. She sets a cup in front of Odessa first. Always Odessa first.

LORRAINE
Mother Smilley, your coffee. Cornelius, you're taking notes on the Pope.

CORNELIUS
I'm taking notes on the year.

In an armchair by the window, scrolling his phone, NEIL SMILLEY (38). Georgia State Senator. Cornelius's eldest. Competent, decent, and dressed exactly like his father, which nobody has ever told him is a little sad.

NEIL
Simone's on in the second half. Roundtable.

CORNELIUS
(not looking up)
I'm aware.

NEIL
You could be proud of her.

CORNELIUS
I could be proud of her if she'd stop explaining Republican tax policy in my mother's living room.

ODESSA
It's MY living room. And she can explain whatever she wants in it. Hush. The man's talking.

BACK TO: "THIS WEEK" STUDIO

GEORGE
Also today, in Brasília, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva will be sworn in this afternoon for a third term as President of Brazil, completing one of the most remarkable political comebacks of our time. His predecessor, Jair Bolsonaro, isn't attending. He flew to Florida on Friday.

Footage: crowds in red already filling the Esplanade of Ministries in Brasília, flags everywhere.

GEORGE (V.O.)
And in Ukraine, the new year arrived with sirens. Russian missiles and Iranian-made drones struck Kyiv and other cities on New Year's Eve and through the night. President Zelenskyy, in a midnight address, told Ukrainians the country will keep fighting for its freedom, and the war, now in its tenth month, shows no sign of a ceasefire.

Footage: an apartment block in Kyiv, a missing wall, a Christmas tree still standing inside.

CHYRON: UKRAINE: NEW YEAR'S ATTACKS ON KYIV — WAR ENTERS 2023

BACK TO: "THIS WEEK" STUDIO

GEORGE
Here at home, the 118th Congress is sworn in on Tuesday, and the first order of business, electing a Speaker of the House, is already a crisis. Republicans won the majority in November by just a handful of seats: 222 to 212. Republican leader Kevin McCarthy needs a majority of those voting, and at least five hardline conservatives have pledged to vote against him. If it goes past one ballot, it'll be the first time that's happened in a hundred years.

CHYRON: SPEAKER SHOWDOWN: McCARTHY FACES REVOLT AHEAD OF TUESDAY VOTE

GEORGE
Meantime, Republican Congressman-elect George Santos of New York, who admitted last week to what he called "embellishing" his résumé — including claims about his education and work history — is set to be sworn in Tuesday, under growing calls to resign before he even takes his seat. And on Friday, the House Ways and Means Committee released six years of former President Trump's tax returns after a years-long legal fight.

George turns slightly. A new graphic: the White House, then a beach at sunset.

GEORGE
President Biden is spending the holiday in St. Croix in the U.S. Virgin Islands, and the question hanging over every one of his vacations now is the same one: will the oldest President in American history run again in 2024? Our correspondent is there.

EXT. CHRISTIANSTED, ST. CROIX — U.S. VIRGIN ISLANDS — MORNING (LIVE REMOTE)

Palm trees. A boardwalk. An ABC NEWS CORRESPONDENT in a blazer that is losing a fight with the humidity.

ABC CORRESPONDENT
George, the President and First Lady have been here since Tuesday. He's been seen at the beach and at a restaurant in town. And aides insist the 2024 decision will come early this year, after the holidays. The White House line is that he "intends" to run. But he turns eighty-two shortly after the next election, and a lot of Democrats are asking, quietly, whether intending is enough.

GEORGE
And on the other side, Donald Trump has been a declared candidate for six weeks now.

ABC CORRESPONDENT
Since November fifteenth. And so far, George, he's the only declared major candidate in either party. Everybody else is waiting to see who blinks.

CHYRON: 2024: TRUMP ONLY MAJOR DECLARED CANDIDATE — BIDEN DECISION EXPECTED "EARLY 2023"

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — CONTINUOUS

CORNELIUS
(writing)
He'll run. He'll run, he'll win the nomination, and he'll be eighty-one by the time of the convention, and every single Democrat in this country will hold their breath for four years.

LORRAINE
And you'll be the one they call to keep the base calm.

CORNELIUS
I am always the one they call.

NEIL
Not in 2017.

A silence. Lorraine's cup pauses halfway to her mouth. Odessa does not turn around, but her eyebrows do something historic.

CORNELIUS
(very calm)
Watch your program, Neil.

BACK TO: "THIS WEEK" STUDIO

GEORGE
When we come back, the economy. Inflation, interest rates, gas prices, and what may be the most chaotic holiday travel season in American history. Plus our powerhouse roundtable on 2024. Stay with us.

CUT TO:

INT. SUNRISE HILL — KITCHEN — EARLY MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 6:11 AM PST

Gray light through enormous windows. Rain tapping. The kitchen is the size of a restaurant and smells like one: butter, vanilla, bacon.

Marc, still in his KID MAYOR shirt, hair a disaster, a spatula in one hand, is flipping pancakes shaped like the numbers 2, 0, 2, and 3. The fake mustache is GONE, but a faint adhesive outline remains.

At the island, wide awake and vibrating with energy: Victoria. She woke him at 5:45 AM by sitting on his chest and saying, "I'm hungry and it's a new year."

On the wall-mounted TV, the "This Week" feed, ABC News Live, streaming on Donohue+. The sound is low.

VICTORIA
Why are you watching the old-people show?

MARC
Because one day you'll be old, and you'll need to know who to blame.

Emma pads in, still in her headband, rubbing her eyes. She climbs onto a stool, assesses the pancakes, and frowns.

EMMA
The three is crooked.

MARC
The three is artistic.

EMMA
It looks like an E.

MARC
Then it's "Two-zero-two-Emma." You're welcome.

Emma tries not to smile. Fails. She is, in every way, Marc in a smaller font.

A white-noise rumble of rain. A phone RINGS. Not a cell. The HOUSE PHONE, a landline on the kitchen wall with a long curly cord. A real one. Marc installed it so the twins would know what they sound like.

VICTORIA
I GOT IT. Bullock residence, Victoria speaking, how may I direct your call?

(listens)
Hi, Grandma Natasha! ...Yes. ...Yes. ...He's making pancakes and he swore once. ...Okay.

(holds out the phone)
Daddy, Grandma says turn on ABC.

MARC
It's on, Mama.

(into the phone, cradled on his shoulder)
Happy New Year. ...What? ...They're doing what?

He grabs the remote. TURNS IT UP.

INT. "THIS WEEK" STUDIO — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:14 AM EST

GEORGE
Welcome back. The economy heading into 2023. The latest numbers: inflation was running at 7.1 percent in November, down from a forty-year high of 9.1 percent in June, but still more than three times the Federal Reserve's target. The Fed raised interest rates seven times last year, and its benchmark rate now sits between four and a quarter and four and a half percent, the highest since 2007.

Graphics: a downward-sloping red line. A mortgage-rate chart climbing like a mountain.

GEORGE (V.O.)
Unemployment remains near historic lows at 3.7 percent. Gas prices have fallen more than a dollar and a half from last summer's record, to about $3.20 a gallon. But the stock market just finished its worst year since 2008, the S&P 500 down nearly twenty percent, and a majority of economists now predict a recession sometime this year.

CHYRON: ECONOMY 2023: INFLATION 7.1% — RECESSION FEARS — DEBT CEILING FIGHT LOOMS

GEORGE
And another deadline is coming fast. The federal government is expected to hit the legal debt limit, about thirty-one point four trillion dollars, within weeks. With a new Republican House demanding spending cuts, a showdown over raising it could dominate the spring.

George turns to a new screen: an airport terminal, a sea of abandoned suitcases.

GEORGE
And for millions of Americans, the holidays were defined by something more personal: getting stranded. Southwest Airlines canceled nearly seventeen thousand flights over the last week and a half after a winter storm overwhelmed its outdated scheduling system. Transportation Secretary Pete Buttigieg has called the meltdown "unacceptable" and promised the department will hold the airline accountable.

Footage: a woman sitting on a baggage carousel crying. A child asleep on a pile of coats at Denver International.

GEORGE (V.O.)
But one stranded family's story went viral for a different reason.

Footage: cellphone video. An elderly Black woman in a wheelchair at Chicago Midway, holding a handwritten sign: "MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK GOT ME HOME TO MY GRANDBABIES."

GEORGE (V.O.)
Beginning last Tuesday, December twenty-seventh, actor Marc-Anthony Bullock, Forbes's richest person in the world, quietly chartered thirty-eight private jets and flew roughly six thousand stranded Southwest passengers home over three days, at no cost to them.

INT. SUNRISE HILL — KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

Victoria's mouth falls open. She points at the TV with a fork.

VICTORIA
DADDY, YOU'RE ON TV AGAIN.

MARC
Again? Dammit —

EMMA
DANG.

MARC
— dang it, I told them no press.

NATASHA (V.O.)
(through the house phone)
You told six thousand people with cellphones no press. Pay attention, baby. This is the part that matters.

INT. "THIS WEEK" STUDIO — CONTINUOUS

GEORGE
The Department of Transportation said Friday it's "reviewing" whether all of the flights complied with federal charter regulations, which strictly limit how private aircraft can carry members of the public. Bullock responded on Instagram.

On screen: a vertical video. Marc, on a tarmac at Van Nuys Airport at night, in a hoodie, surrounded by jets and grandmothers.

MARC (ON SCREEN)
If the Department of Transportation wants to fine me for getting somebody's grandma home for Christmas, they can send the bill to Sunrise Hill. I'll frame it. I'll hang it next to my Emmy. I'll pay it in pennies. In person. Merry Christmas, Pete, I love you, please don't arrest me.

George allows himself a small smile.

GEORGE
The Transportation Department declined to comment further. Southwest Airlines says it will reimburse affected passengers' expenses.

CHYRON: BULLOCK "AIRLIFT" FLEW 6,000 STRANDED TRAVELERS HOME — DOT "REVIEWING" CHARTER RULES

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:17 AM EST

Cornelius has stopped writing. He's staring at the TV. At Marc's face. Lorraine watches him watch.

Slowly, Cornelius writes on his legal pad, in his precise congressional handwriting: "12/27–29: 38 charters. DOT review. FAA Part 135? Public carriage w/o certificate?"

LORRAINE
You're taking notes on the man's charity.

CORNELIUS
I'm taking notes on his violations.

ODESSA
(without looking back)
He got a woman in a wheelchair home to her grandbabies, Cornelius.

CORNELIUS
He broke federal aviation law and dared the Secretary of Transportation to do something about it. On camera. Again.

ODESSA
And what are you gonna do about it? Call Pete Buttigieg? On New Year's Day? Tell him your son-in-law's too nice?

Neil snorts into his coffee. Cornelius closes the legal pad. Neatly. Precisely. The way a man closes a file he intends to reopen.

INT. SUNRISE HILL — KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

MARC
(into the house phone)
Mama, it's fine. Pete's not gonna fine me. Pete's a reasonable man. Pete's from Indiana.

NATASHA (V.O.)
It's not Pete I'm worried about.

Marc knows exactly who she means. He glances toward the stairs. Esther isn't down yet.

MARC
(quieter)
It's New Year's, Mama.

NATASHA (V.O.)
He doesn't take holidays, baby. Neither do I. Stay on the roundtable. I hear his daughter's on.

MARC
Which one?

NATASHA (V.O.)
The one who isn't yours.

CLICK. Marc hangs the house phone back on the wall. Victoria is staring at him.

VICTORIA
Did Grandma just hang up on you?

MARC
Grandma doesn't hang up. Grandma concludes.

ACT TWO — "THE ROUNDTABLE"

INT. "THIS WEEK" STUDIO — ROUNDTABLE SET — MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 9:31 AM EST

A curved glass table. Four guests. George at the head.

SIMONE SMILLEY (35), Republican strategist and network contributor. Navy suit, natural hair pulled back, pearl studs that used to be her grandmother's. She has her father's jaw and her grandmother's mouth: one built to win arguments, the other built to end them.

Across from her, PATRICIA "PATTI" GROVE (58), Democratic strategist, former senior White House official, a Baltimore accent she's never bothered to sand down.

Two other panelists, a CONSERVATIVE COLUMNIST and a POLITICAL REPORTER, round out the table.

CHYRON: ROUNDTABLE: THE ROAD TO 2024

GEORGE
Simone, let me start with you. Donald Trump is in. Ron DeSantis just won re-election in Florida by nineteen points and hasn't said a word about 2024. If you're advising Republicans this morning, what's the play?

SIMONE
Honestly, George? Patience. Republicans just had a midterm where the red wave turned out to be a red puddle. Nearly every swing-state candidate who ran on relitigating 2020 lost. The voters sent a message: they want competence, not chaos. And the person who seems to have heard it loudest is in Tallahassee, not Mar-a-Lago.

GEORGE
You think DeSantis runs.

SIMONE
I think DeSantis is running. He just hasn't told his feet yet.

The panel laughs.

PATTI
And Democrats should send him a fruit basket, because a DeSantis–Trump primary is the bloodiest fight in modern Republican history. We'll sell popcorn.

SIMONE
Your candidate is eighty, Patti.

PATTI
And undefeated against Donald Trump.

SIMONE
One-and-oh is a record, not a strategy.

OOOH from the CONSERVATIVE COLUMNIST. George steps in.

GEORGE
Let me ask about the lesson of 2022 on both sides. Celebrity candidates had a rough cycle. Dr. Oz lost in Pennsylvania. Herschel Walker lost the Georgia runoff just last month. Is the era of the celebrity candidate over?

SIMONE
I think so. 2016 was the exception that proved the rule. Voters looked at Oz and Walker and said, "We like you on TV. We don't want you in the Senate." Fame gets you on the ballot now. It doesn't get you over the line.

PATTI
Unless the celebrity is Marc-Anthony Bullock.

Big laughter around the table. The Political Reporter actually claps once.

PATTI
I'm serious! Did you see what he did with the airplanes this week? He'd win fifty states and Puerto Rico, and Puerto Rico can't even vote for President.

CONSERVATIVE COLUMNIST
He'd also be under indictment by the FAA by Iowa.

GEORGE
(smiling)
He's also thirty years old. The Constitution says thirty-five.

PATTI
See, that's the only thing stopping him. Not the polls. The birth certificate.

Everyone turns, almost involuntarily, to Simone. She knows they would. She takes a long, deliberate sip of water.

SIMONE
I want to be very clear for the record. As a member of the Smilley family, I am contractually, spiritually, and Thanksgiving-ly obligated to say: no comment.

The table ERUPTS. Even George laughs out loud.

GEORGE
For viewers who don't know, Simone's sister is married to Mr. Bullock.

SIMONE
My baby sister, George. And my nieces think he hung the moon. And he probably could, he's got the money. That's all you're getting.

CHYRON: SMILLEY ON BROTHER-IN-LAW BULLOCK 2024 BUZZ: "NO COMMENT"

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:36 AM EST

Odessa is laughing so hard she has to put her coffee down. Lorraine has a hand over her mouth. Neil is grinning openly.

Cornelius is not moving. At all.

ODESSA
Thanksgiving-ly! Oh, that child is a Smilley. That child is a Smilley through and through.

CORNELIUS
That child just made a joke about the Bullock presidency on national television.

LORRAINE
It was a joke, Cornelius. He's thirty. He's a comedian. He doesn't want to be President.

CORNELIUS
Nobody wants to be President until somebody tells them they could be.

He picks the legal pad back up. Writes one line. Underlines it twice.

INSERT — THE LEGAL PAD: "1/1/23 — 'He'd win fifty states.' — Patti Grove, ABC."

NEIL
You're writing down jokes now?

CORNELIUS
I'm writing down the first time someone said it out loud.

INT. SUNRISE HILL — KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:37 AM PST

Marc has a pancake halfway to his mouth. Frozen. Emma and Victoria stare at the TV, then at him, then at the TV.

EMMA
Daddy. Auntie Simone said you could hang the moon.

MARC
Auntie Simone is a Republican, baby. They exaggerate.

VICTORIA
Could you, though?

MARC
Hang the moon? Not without a permit.

Esther appears at the bottom of the stairs in a robe, hair wrapped, having heard the whole thing from the landing.

ESTHER
Did my sister just do a bit about you on "This Week"?

MARC
Your sister just did a TIGHT FIVE about me on "This Week." She killed. I'm so proud. I'm also a little scared.

ESTHER
And the lady said...

MARC
Fifty states and Puerto Rico. Which is very sweet. And illegal. On two levels.

Esther crosses to him, steals the crooked "3" pancake off his plate, and eats it.

ESTHER
My daddy's watching this.

MARC
Your daddy's watching everything, Smilley. Your daddy's the NSA in a cardigan.

She laughs despite herself. Then her phone buzzes. She doesn't even have to look.

INT. "THIS WEEK" STUDIO — ROUNDTABLE — CONTINUOUS

GEORGE
One more topic before we go. Business and culture. It was a brutal year for media companies: layoffs, streaming losses, stock prices cut in half across the industry. With one very large exception.

Graphic: the Benny Bluebird logo over the Sunrise Tower. A stock chart. Unlike every other chart on this show, it's going up.

GEORGE (V.O.)
Donohue Entertainment, the hundred-year-old Burbank giant, closed 2022 as the most valuable company in the world at roughly one-and-a-half trillion dollars. As of this morning, its 20th Century Studios release "Avatar: The Way of Water" has crossed a billion dollars worldwide in just over two weeks. Marvel's "Black Panther: Wakanda Forever" is closing in on 850 million. And Donohue Plus and Hulu together now count more than three hundred million subscribers.

POLITICAL REPORTER
And Donohue is heading into 2023 in open warfare with the Governor of Florida.

GEORGE
DeSantis is sworn in for his second term on Tuesday, and he's made the company's special self-governing district around Donohue World a centerpiece of his fight against what he calls "woke corporations."

SIMONE
And for the record, George, conservatives aren't angry at Benny Bluebird. They're angry at a trillion-dollar company that thinks it's a government.

PATTI
That company employs eighty thousand Floridians.

SIMONE
And it can afford a lobbyist for every one of them.

George nods and turns back to the camera.

GEORGE
Hollywood itself faces a reckoning this year. The Writers Guild contract expires May first, the actors' union contract on June thirtieth, and with artificial intelligence suddenly in everyone's hands, last month's launch of ChatGPT has the entire creative industry asking what its future looks like. Both unions say the threat of strikes is real.

GEORGE (V.O.)
And one more number. According to Forbes, the richest person on the planet at the start of 2023 remains Marc-Anthony Bullock, Donohue heir, actor, filmmaker, and founder of the private conglomerate Bullock Holdings, with an estimated fortune of more than nine hundred and ninety billion dollars. The world's second-richest person, LVMH's Bernard Arnault, sits at about one hundred and seventy billion. The distance between number one and number two, about eight hundred and twenty billion dollars, is roughly the size of the entire Swiss economy.

CHYRON: FORBES: BULLOCK STILL WORLD'S RICHEST — ~$990B; ARNAULT A DISTANT #2

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — HOME GYM — HOLMBY HILLS, LOS ANGELES — MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 6:42 AM PST

A glass box overlooking a lawn so green it looks digitally enhanced. On a treadmill, at a pace that would embarrass most forty-year-olds: VICTOR DONOHUE (76), Chairman of Donohue Entertainment. Looks fifty-five. A face that's been on movie posters since Nixon.

On a yoga mat, in a perfect, unwavering plank: JOAN DONOHUE (74). Looks fifty. Former Spelman girl from Atlanta. Legend. She hasn't missed a morning since 1979.

On a bench with a tablet, already in a suit on a holiday: NATASHA BULLOCK (51). CEO. Looks thirty-five. The stillness of a woman who can end a career with a single unanswered email.

Beside her, nursing a coffee and reading a physical newspaper like a man from another century: ROBERT BULLOCK (53). Director. Looks forty. The quietest person in any room he's ever been in.

VICTOR
(not breaking stride)
"The size of the Swiss economy." That's going to be a problem.

NATASHA
It's been a problem since Bitcoin went over a thousand dollars.

ROBERT
Our son flew six thousand people home for Christmas, and the network leads with his net worth.

NATASHA
Our network, Robert.

ROBERT
I know. That's what bothers me.

On the screen, Simone, still at the roundtable, mid-sentence. Joan, in her plank, turns her head just slightly to look.

JOAN
Is that the middle Smilley girl?

NATASHA
Simone. The Republican.

A long beat. Joan holds the plank. Her arms don't shake. Her voice does, almost imperceptibly.

JOAN
She has his eyes.

VICTOR
(gently, without looking)
Joan.

Natasha looks between her parents. She knows that tone. She has never been told the whole story behind it.

NATASHA
Whose eyes, Mama?

JOAN
(coming up out of the plank, smooth)
Nobody's, baby. An old friend. Atlanta was a long time ago.

Joan dabs her face with a towel. Nobody in the room believes her. Nobody says so.

VICTOR
Tell me about Florida.

NATASHA
Ron's sworn in Tuesday. He'll do something loud by the end of February. He's going to try to take the district.

VICTOR
He can try to take the district.

NATASHA
He can dissolve a district, Daddy. He can't dissolve Benny. Forty million people walk through those gates every year. Half of them vote in Florida.

VICTOR
And the unions?

NATASHA
The writers will strike. The actors might. And when they do, I'll be sitting across the table from my own son.

Robert lowers his newspaper.

ROBERT
And whose side will he be on?

NATASHA
He'll be on the side of whoever's hurting, Robert. Like always. That's what scares me.

Victor finally slows the treadmill. Steps off. Not even winded.

VICTOR
And Cornelius?

NATASHA
Cornelius watched every second of that segment with a legal pad. I'd bet the company on it.

VICTOR
Don't bet the company, baby. We've done that before.

ACT THREE — "THE INTERNET HAS ENTERED THE CHAT"

MONTAGE — THE INTERNET — SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — MORNING INTO AFTERNOON

Twitter · @ThisWeekABC

"Unless the celebrity is Marc-Anthony Bullock... he'd win fifty states and Puerto Rico." — @PattiGrove on the 2024 field. Watch:

4,812 Retweets · 22.9K Likes · 9:41 AM EST

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

For the record, my "no comment" stands. My nieces' comment is "he can hang the moon." I don't control the youth. Happy New Year.

18.3K Retweets · 141K Likes · 10:02 AM EST

Twitter · @bullpenbrigade

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK 2024. I don't care that he's 30. Change the Constitution. We changed it for less.

22K Retweets · 98K Likes · 10:14 AM EST

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

The fact that a Sunday show spent a full minute joking about a 30-year-old actor for President tells you everything about the state of American politics in 2023.

3,211 Retweets · 14K Likes · 10:20 AM EST

Twitter · @kidmayorstan

KID MAYOR TO PRESIDENT PIPELINE IS REAL. HE LITERALLY PLAYED A 13 YEAR OLD MAYOR. IT WAS FORESHADOWING.

31K Retweets · 176K Likes · 10:33 AM EST

TikTok · @gramma.flies.free

[Video: the elderly woman from Chicago Midway, wheelchair, gold reading glasses, looking dead into the camera] "I don't know what a Constitution is gonna tell me. That boy got me home. He got my vote. He can have my house."

11.2M views · 2.4M likes

Twitter · @AviationLawyerJen

Good thread on why the Bullock "airlift" may have violated 14 CFR Part 135. Nobody's arguing it wasn't kind. It's still federal law. 1/14

2,109 Retweets · 7.7K Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"ABC roundtable jokes about Marc-Anthony Bullock 2024 — Constitution says 35, he's 30"

41.2K upvotes · 6,880 comments · Top comment: "He'd be 33 by inauguration day. So close and yet so constitutionally far."

Twitter · #MarcForPresident

Trending in United States · 214K Tweets

Twitter · @PatriotMom1776

Nobody wants a Hollywood billionaire president. We have enough clowns in DC.

1,422 Retweets · 6,990 Likes

Twitter · @PatriotMom1776's reply section

@DeepDishDad: "ma'am he flew my mother home from Midway for free"

11K Likes

VARIETY

Donohue Closes 2022 at $1.5 Trillion as 'Avatar: The Way of Water' Crosses $1 Billion

The Burbank giant enters its centennial year as the world's most valuable company — and Hollywood's biggest labor-negotiation target.

DEADLINE

Tyrese Avery's 'Rockin' Eve' Performance Draws Show's Biggest Social Engagement in a Decade

"Afterglow" streams up 340% overnight; ABC calls it "a once-in-a-generation New Year's moment."

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Marc-Anthony Bullock's Holiday 'Airlift' Puts DOT in Awkward Spot

Inside the 38-jet operation, the regulators reviewing it, and the actor who told the Transportation Secretary, "Please don't arrest me."

POLITICO PLAYBOOK

Sunday Shows Ring In 2023 With Speaker Chaos, Biden 2024 Questions — and One Very Rich Joke

McCarthy allies count votes; the White House insists the President "intends" to run; ABC's roundtable goes viral for a 30-year-old who can't legally run.

AXIOS

Scoop: At least five House conservatives vow to oppose McCarthy on first ballot

The math: McCarthy can lose only four Republicans if every member votes.

THE NEW YORK TIMES

Benedict XVI, Theologian Who Became the First Pope in Centuries to Resign, Dies at 95

THE WASHINGTON POST

Lula Sworn In as Brazil's President, Completing Stunning Return

FORBES

The World's Richest Person Starts 2023 Nearly $820 Billion Ahead of No. 2

Marc-Anthony Bullock's mostly private fortune keeps compounding. Is the first trillionaire just months away?

TMZ

MARC-ANTHONY'S NYE: FAKE MIDNIGHT, FAKE MUSTACHE, REAL CAVIAR DISASTER

Sources say Grace Bullock "fully took out" a $40K caviar tower around midnight PT.

INT. THE PIERRE HOTEL — PRESIDENTIAL SUITE — MANHATTAN — MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 10:12 AM EST

Blackout curtains, cracked open six inches. Central Park white with fog. Tyrese, face-down on a bed the size of a parking space, still in the silver jacket, phone glowing an inch from his face.

A group chat. The thread name: "BALDWIN HILLS HOOLIGANS." Members: Marc, Amond, Tyler, Tyrese.

TYRESE — 10:12 AM

why is my phone saying #MarcForPresident is trending. what did u do. who did u fly

AMOND — 7:13 AM PST

he flew 6,000 grandmas. and Simone did a bit about him on This Week. and a lady said 50 states and Puerto Rico

TYLER — 7:13 AM PST

Constitutionally he's a minor. Respect your elders. I'm 31 Wednesday

MARC — 7:14 AM PST

Tyrese you sang that note so long I aged. I'm 35 now. I'm eligible. Thanks bro

TYRESE — 10:15 AM

LMAOOOO. Marc for President. Secretary of Vocals: me

MARC — 7:15 AM PST

Nobody's running for anything. I can barely run a pancake griddle. Emma said my 3 looked like an E

AMOND — 7:16 AM PST

it did look like an E

MARC — 7:16 AM PST

Amond you're my brother but I will have you deported to Inglewood

TYLER — 7:17 AM PST

As your only Republican friend, for the record: I would vote for you, and my daddy in Houston would vote for you, and he hasn't voted for a Democrat since Jimmy Carter's peanut farm

MARC — 7:17 AM PST

Tell your daddy I said thank you and I'm still not running. Happy New Year hooligans. Love y'all. Tyrese drink water

Tyrese drops the phone onto his chest, laughing to himself. Stares at the ceiling.

TYRESE
(to nobody)
...He'd win, though.

ACT FOUR — "THE PLAN"

INT. SUNRISE HILL — MASTER SUITE BALCONY — MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 7:31 AM PST / 10:31 AM EST

Rain clearing. Steam rising off the hills. Esther, wrapped in a cashmere throw, phone to her ear. Through the glass door behind her, Marc braids Victoria's hair on the bed. He's terrible at it. Victoria doesn't care.

INTERCUT — INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — CORNELIUS'S STUDY — ATLANTA — SAME TIME

Mahogany. Leather. A wall of framed bill signings. The smell of old paper and older grudges. Cornelius, alone, at his desk, the door closed.

CORNELIUS
Happy New Year, sweetheart.

ESTHER
Happy New Year, Daddy. You were up at three.

CORNELIUS
I'm always up at three. History doesn't sleep. Did you watch your sister?

ESTHER
I heard her.

CORNELIUS
She's very funny. Your grandmother laughed so hard she spilled on the good rug. Esther. Listen to me. 2023 is the year we stop talking and start doing.

ESTHER
Daddy —

CORNELIUS
Congressman Whitfield is retiring. He'll announce in March. I've made sure of it. The seat is as close to ours as anything has been since I left it. You move home by summer. You establish residency. You spend the fall at every church, every sorority, every barbershop in that district. You announce in January of 2024, and on November fifth, 2024, the name Smilley goes back on a federal ballot. Where it belongs.

ESTHER
Move home. To Atlanta.

CORNELIUS
It IS home.

ESTHER
My home is in Los Angeles. My daughters are in school in Los Angeles. My husband —

CORNELIUS
Your husband can buy a house in Buckhead with what he spends on jet fuel in a week. He's demonstrated that. On ABC.

Esther closes her eyes.

ESTHER
Don't.

CORNELIUS
I'm not doing anything. I'm describing. A man who violates federal aviation law to make a point. A man who tells cabinet secretaries "please don't arrest me" on a video viewed by, what is it now, forty million people? A man that roundtables joke about running for President. Esther, you are thirty years old. Your Shirley Temple years are behind you. Shirley Temple became an ambassador. You can become much more. But not if every story about you is a story about him.

ESTHER
(quiet, steady)
Every story about me IS a story about him, Daddy. That's what being married means.

A long, cold silence on the line. Cornelius looks at the framed photo on his desk: a ten-year-old Esther in a Donohue Channel costume, curls bouncing, winning her first Kids' Choice Award. Next to it, turned face-down, a picture he doesn't look at.

CORNELIUS
Think about the plan. That's all I'm asking. Think about it.

ESTHER
I always think about it. That's the problem.

She hangs up. Turns around. Marc is standing in the doorway. Victoria's half-finished braid sticks straight out of her head like an antenna.

MARC
How bad?

ESTHER
He wants me to move to Atlanta by summer and run for Congress in 2024.

MARC
In a district he's already emptying.

ESTHER
"I've made sure of it."

Marc nods slowly. No anger. Just a kind of tired sadness.

MARC
You want me to call him? I'll be nice. Mostly nice. Like eighty percent.

ESTHER
Don't call him.

MARC
Seventy percent.

ESTHER
Marc.

MARC
Okay. I won't call him.

(beat)
Do YOU want to run?

The question lands. Nobody has asked her that. Not once, in twenty years.

ESTHER
...I don't know. Nobody's ever asked me.

MARC
Well, I'm asking. And whatever you say, I'm in. Atlanta, LA, the moon, if your sister's right and I can hang it. You're not his golden ticket, Smilley. You're my wife. That means you get to pick.

Esther looks at him for a long time. Then she walks across the room and fixes Victoria's antenna braid, because somebody has to.

VICTORIA
Mommy, are you running for something?

ESTHER
Only from your father's braiding.

MARC
Wow. In front of the children.

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — CORNELIUS'S STUDY — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 10:41 AM EST

Cornelius sets the phone down. Sits very still.

He stands. Crosses to a framed lithograph of the Edmund Pettus Bridge. Swings it away from the wall on a hinge. Behind it, a steel safe. He spins the dial without looking. It opens.

Inside: a three-ring binder, four inches thick, with a white spine label in his handwriting:

"THE BULLOCK FILE."

He lays it on the desk. Flips past tabs: "2012 — PREGNANCY." "2014 — MERIDIAN DEAL." "2017 — THE ROAST." "2019 — LUNCH DEBT LITIGATION." "2020 — PPE / CUSTOMS." "2022 — FDA / FORMULA."

He adds a new tab. Writes on it: "2022 — DOT / CHARTERS." Then he tears the top sheet off his legal pad and three-hole-punches it with a heavy brass punch that has been in this family since the Carter administration.

The door creaks. Lorraine, in the doorway, a coffee cup in each hand.

LORRAINE
It's New Year's Day, Cornelius.

CORNELIUS
Twenty-two months, Lorraine.

LORRAINE
Until what?

CORNELIUS
Until November fifth, 2024. Twenty-two months until our daughter's name is on a ballot.

(he clicks the binder shut)
Nothing gets in the way. Nothing. And nobody.

Lorraine sets his coffee down on the binder. Right on the label. A ring of steam.

LORRAINE
She said no, didn't she.

CORNELIUS
She said she'd think about it.

LORRAINE
Mm-hm. That's what I said when you proposed.

She leaves. Cornelius looks down at the coffee ring spreading across "THE BULLOCK FILE." He doesn't move the cup.

TAG

INT. SUNRISE HILL — FAMILY ROOM — DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 1, 2023 — 4:20 PM PST

The house is finally quiet. Rain gone. Golden afternoon light. Guests have scattered. Amond and Harmony are asleep upright on a loveseat. Lyric is curled between them, awake, watching.

Emma, Victoria, and Lyric are on the floor in a nest of blankets. Marc is lying on the couch above them, one arm hanging down so Victoria can hold his hand while she watches.

On the TV, Donohue Plus is playing a series from 2006. Grainy. Brightly lit. A laugh track.

On screen: a FOURTEEN-YEAR-OLD MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK in an oversized suit and a mayoral sash, standing at a tiny podium in a fake town square. Behind him, a fourteen-year-old Amond in a too-big "DEPUTY MAYOR" sash, and a fourteen-year-old Tayia rolling her eyes in pigtails.

The title card: KID MAYOR — SEASON 1, EPISODE 1: "VOTE FOR ME (I'M SERIOUS)."

YOUNG MARC (ON SCREEN)
Citizens of Maple Falls! If you elect me, I promise: no more homework on Fridays, free tacos on Tuesdays, and I'll make Wednesday a second Saturday!

The laugh track roars. Lyric giggles. Victoria cackles. Emma looks up at her real father, deeply suspicious.

EMMA
Daddy. You were a mayor?

MARC
Of a fake town. For three seasons. Best job I ever had. No Congress.

LYRIC
Did you win?

MARC
By a landslide, Lyric-bird. Write-in. Unopposed. The other kid's mom moved to Ohio.

VICTORIA
You should do it for real.

Marc laughs. Easy. Unbothered. He means every word.

MARC
Baby, nobody wants me running anything. I set the kitchen on fire making pancakes this morning.

EMMA
That was a small fire.

MARC
See? She gets it.

Lyric isn't laughing anymore. She's looking at the screen, at the little boy with the sash, then at the grown man on the couch, with the dead-serious concentration only an eight-year-old can manage.

LYRIC
(quiet, to herself)
...You'd be good at it, though.

Nobody hears her but Esther, in the doorway, holding a mug of tea. She looks at Lyric. Then at Marc. Then at the boy in the sash on the screen.

And for just a second, something passes over her face that she doesn't understand yet.

On screen, Young Marc bangs a gavel that's way too big for him.

YOUNG MARC (ON SCREEN)
This meeting of Maple Falls is now in session!

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER ONE

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 1

Timeline: Sat Dec 31, 2022, 11:56 PM EST → Sun Jan 1, 2023, 4:20 PM PST.

Ages (on Jan 1, 2023): Marc 30 (turns 31 Thu Jan 5) · Esther 30 · Emma & Victoria 10 · Lyric 8 · Amond 30 · Harmony 30 · Tyrese 31 · Tyler 30 (turns 31 Wed Jan 4) · Tayia 30 · Arianna 30 · Elxa 32 · Grace 28 · Natasha 51 · Robert 53 · Victor 76 · Joan 74 · Odessa 94 · Cornelius 64 · Lorraine 61 · Neil 38 · Simone 35 · George Stephanopoulos 61 · Ryan Seacrest 48.

Real events depicted: Pope Emeritus Benedict XVI's death (Dec 31, 2022) and upcoming funeral (Thu Jan 5); Lula's inauguration (Jan 1); New Year's Russian strikes on Kyiv; Speaker vote set for Tue Jan 3; George Santos résumé scandal; release of Trump tax returns (Dec 30); Biden in St. Croix; Trump declared Nov 15, 2022; Nov 2022 CPI 7.1%; Fed rate 4.25–4.50%; unemployment 3.7%; gas about $3.20; looming debt limit; Southwest meltdown (~17,000 cancellations); "Avatar: The Way of Water" passing $1B; DeSantis second inauguration Tue Jan 3; WGA (May 1) and SAG-AFTRA (June 30) contract expirations; ChatGPT (Nov 30, 2022); celebrity candidates Oz and Walker losing in 2022.

New canon established: Marc's Southwest "airlift" (Dec 27–29, 2022: 38 jets, ~6,000 passengers; DOT reviewing). Donohue's ABC News Live streams on Donohue+. The Sunrise Hill kitchen has a landline. The "Baldwin Hills Hooligans" group chat (Marc, Amond, Tyler, Tyrese). Cornelius's plan: Esther moves to Atlanta by summer 2023, runs in 2024 for the seat of retiring Congressman Whitfield (fictional; announcement expected March 2023), which Cornelius has engineered. The Bullock File is kept in a safe behind the Edmund Pettus Bridge lithograph in Cornelius's study, with a new tab added: "2022 — DOT / CHARTERS." Joan, seeing Simone: "She has his eyes" (Thaddeus); Natasha has never been told the full story. Kid Mayor S1E1: "Vote for Me (I'm Serious)," set in the fictional town of Maple Falls; Amond played the Deputy Mayor. Lyric's seed: "You'd be good at it, though." Esther overhears.

Fictional people introduced: Patricia "Patti" Grove (58, Democratic strategist); Congressman Whitfield (D-GA, retiring).

Looming event (in-world): the 2024 presidential election.